

The Struggle to “Do Life Right” in an Always-Online World: Teens, Mobile Phones, and the Limits of Individual Responsibility

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Abstract

Today’s teens have grown up with mobile phones and social media mediating daily routines, social relationships, and schooling, yet their experiences are often reduced to narratives of distraction, mental health risks, and addiction. In this paper we present a qualitative study including a questionnaire ($n = 47$) and focus groups ($n = 34$) with upper-level high school students to examine how they experience mobile phone and social media use and how they believe they are perceived by adult figures and media. Our findings show that teens encounter phones as infrastructural rather than optional, with use shaped by expectations of availability and participation. Teens described situational strategies for managing phone use around studying and sleep, alongside ambivalent social media experiences. Teens reflected on limits of self-regulation within environments demanding connectivity, pointing to a need for re-distributed responsibility between teens, adults, school leadership and platform design.

CCS Concepts

• Human-centered computing → Interaction design; Empirical studies in interaction design;

Keywords

Mobile phones, social media, teens, device ban

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1 Introduction

Public discourse around high school students’ use of mobile phones, and especially social media, has over the last decade steered towards worries about mental health [54, 60], decreasing academic performance [9], and lacking of face-to-face social skills [90]. These concerns are often framed as widespread, with mobile phones positioned as a central driver of teen distress [17, 40, 41, 55, 78, 89, 90]. Teens themselves express ambivalence: while many report feeling more socially connected through social media, they also believe it may be harming people their age [36].

Amid these anxieties, mobile phones have become deeply embedded in adolescents’ everyday lives. For today’s teens, phones mediate routines of studying, sleeping, socializing, and coordinating with peers and adults. They are not merely entertainment devices, but tools for communication, organization, and participation in social life. Yet much of the public conversation reduces teens’ phone use to individual failures of self-control or addiction, leaving limited space to examine how young people themselves experience and manage phones as part of their daily environments. It also overlooks the structural conditions under which phone use occurs—as part of broader sociotechnical arrangements and infrastructures.

Against this backdrop, governments and schools across the U.S. and abroad have begun introducing restrictions on mobile phones and social media use. These efforts are often motivated by concerns about attention, learning, sleep, and adolescent well-being, as well as broader public debates linking intensive mobile phone and social media use to mental health outcomes [31, 41, 89]. In practice, policies range from school-level device management strategies—such as sealed pouches, lockers, or confiscation—to broader regulatory interventions that target platform design and youth access [4].

Recent examples illustrate the scope of this shift. Several U.S. states and districts have piloted full-day smartphone bans framed around reducing disruption, bullying [31, 47, 57], and distraction while improving student engagement [33, 39, 81] alongside parent-led initiatives such as Wait Until 8th that seek to delay early smartphone adoption [1]. At the national level, Australia enacted legislation in 2025 restricting minors’ access to major social media platforms [53], while U.S. states have pursued complementary approaches, including New York’s SAFE for Kids Act, which limits



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algorithmic personalization and nighttime notifications for users under 18 [52], and California’s age-verification requirements for certain online services [50]. Together, these developments signal a growing turn toward age-based constraints on mobile and platform use, even as implementation and enforcement vary widely across contexts and jurisdictions.

Despite intensifying public concern, expanding regulation, and frequent attention to extreme outcomes—such as bullying [2, 15, 49, 92], academic failure [7], and self-harm—relatively little research has examined how high school students themselves experience everyday life with personal mobile devices. How do teens make sense of having phones available around the clock? How do they manage their own use in relation to studying, time, and sleep, and what consequences do they perceive as emerging from these practices? And how do they feel their practices are viewed and judged in today’s teen setting?

To answer some of these questions and take a closer look at teens’ experiences, we conducted a qualitative study at a public high school in a Northeastern state in the U.S. that had not yet enacted mobile phone bans. We wanted to hear from the high school students themselves [66], how they perceived their uses and practices and how they situated themselves within the broader media criticism surrounding youth phone use.

In this paper, we present findings from a study consisting of a questionnaire ($n = 47$) and six focus groups ($n = 34$) with primarily junior and senior high school students ages 15–18. We examine teens’ everyday phone practices, including how mobile phones are embedded in daily routines, how teens manage time and attention around studying and sleep, how they engage with social media, and how they perceive the consequences and limits of their own phone use.

In this study we ask the following three research questions:

- RQ1:** How do high school students describe their use of mobile phones?
- RQ2:** How do high school students perceive the differences between their own practices and their parents’ and other adult’s attitudes towards their use of mobile phones?
- RQ3:** Which aspects of mobile phone use do students perceive as beneficial or positive, and which ones are perceived as harmful or challenging for their mental health and well being?

Rather than identifying novel patterns of teen mobile phone use, this paper reframes how this kind of use is understood. Drawing on qualitative accounts, we show that teens’ experience with mobile phones often borders on them not being optional tools. Rather they are infrastructural systems embedded in expectations of reachability, coordination, and social participation. While the burden of managing phone use has historically been seen as an individual problem, despite being shaped by broader sociotechnical arrangements, this framing obscures the limits of individual self-regulation. We instead call for understanding phone use as a distributed problem that spans platform, families, and institutions.

This paper contributes: (1) an empirical account of how teens experience mobile phones as infrastructural systems of reachability and coordination; (2) a conceptual reframing of phone use as a site of distributed responsibility; (3) implications for designing beyond

individual behavior change toward addressing broader sociotechnical conditions.

2 Related Literature

2.1 Ambivalent Relationships of Teens and their Mobile Phones

Teens’ relationships with their phones are increasingly characterized by ambivalence and growing fear about its harms [36, 62], as well as patterns of problematic use [95]. Against this backdrop, teens’ own accounts of phone use reflect tension rather than straightforward dependence or rejection [36]. While many report valuing creativity, connection, and self-expression, they also express concern that constant access undermines face-to-face interaction and attentional presence. Some adolescents describe feeling “happy and peaceful” when disconnected, while others experience anxiety or discomfort without their devices [8, 20, 80]. Rather than disengaging entirely, youth often pursue forms of self-regulation: prior work documents teens intentionally adding friction—such as enabling grayscale displays or removing apps—as a way of managing habitual use while remaining connected [85].

Other research suggests that youth may be relatively untroubled by privacy-invasive personalization, particularly when algorithmic systems are perceived as inevitable or beyond individual control [69]. This sense of resignation has been observed across studies of datafication and algorithmic influence [21, 86]. Research of young adults suggests that non-use and disconnection are rarely absolute and that people develop partial, situational strategies for modulating connectivity [56]. Natarajan [73] discusses how young people construct frictions or “exit paths” to disengagement, but also shows how this is negotiated, temporary, and highly context-dependent.

At the same time, mobile phones serve as primary gateways to social media and other networked platforms that provide real benefits, including access to community, social capital, sense of safety and emotional support [11, 29, 35, 36, 72]. Adolescents may translate online ties into offline socializing, using digital communication to sustain in-person relationships [29]. Social media platforms can also spur civic participation, while increasing exposure to misinformation and polarizing content [43, 75].

Nevertheless, heavy or stressful use has been associated with isolation from peers and family, social stress, disrupted sleep—the rationale behind recent legislation to regulate social media platforms nighttime notifications to users under 18 [52]—self-image concerns [93], harassment, and bullying [2, 15, 37, 49, 92]. Public concern about these dynamics has intensified in recent years and research illustrates a clear narrative around teen’s use of smart phones as addictive and problematic [58], with social media playing a significant part [38]. A 2024 national survey reports that many Gen Z respondents—particularly LGBTQ youth and women—view social media as harmful to society, with a sizeable minority perceiving harm to their own lives [42]. These concerns have been echoed in the U.S. Surgeon General’s advisory on youth mental health [40], whistleblower disclosures [45], and heightened attention to cyberbullying and related harms [23, 31, 89]. While scholars caution against monocausal explanations that attribute youth mental health outcomes solely to social media use [14] it is nevertheless clear that something is wrong with teens using social media.

Within HCI, most prior work has focused on refining platforms and interfaces to mitigate specific harms—such as cyberbullying, harassment, and misinformation—while preserving the perceived benefits of social media use [43, 46, 94]. As a result, comparatively less attention has been paid to how adolescents integrate phones into the rhythms of everyday life, including how mobile device use intersects with studying, time management, attention, and social coordination across the day.

Phones are especially contested in school settings, where they are often framed as sources of distraction while also serving social and educational functions. Teachers, parents, and administrators frequently describe smartphones as disruptive to learning, even as they acknowledge their occasional instructional or communicative value [10, 44, 87]. More recently, the use of AI for school work has also been questioned in the high school learning ecology [83]. As a result, adolescents' everyday phone practices around studying and time management often unfold against a backdrop of mixed expectations and informal constraints rather than consistent institutional rules.

2.2 Early Social Media to Ubiquitous Mobile Platforms

Much of the foundational research on youth social media emerged during an earlier period dominated by platforms such as Facebook and Twitter, when engagement was more episodic and often tied to desktop or laptop access [12, 16, 30]. In these contexts, social media use was frequently conceptualized as occurring in discrete sessions—logging in to post updates, browse feeds, or interact with peers—rather than as a persistent background presence.

Subsequent work shifted attention toward identity management and boundary negotiation, examining how youth navigated visibility, privacy, and self-presentation across networked audiences [63–65]. This research highlighted how social media enabled connection and expression while simultaneously introducing new forms of surveillance and vulnerability, shaping how young people calibrated what to share and with whom.

More recent scholarship has emphasized how platform design and economic incentives shape these experiences, drawing attention to the ways social media systems operationalize data, engagement, and affect in service of platform goals [48, 67]. This work situates vulnerability within broader sociotechnical economic arrangements that structures participation and visibility online [24, 96].

Contemporary social media environments differ in important ways from earlier platforms. Today's systems are predominantly mobile-first, deeply integrated into smartphones, and shaped by algorithmic feeds that continually surface content and notifications in ways that are not always fully legible to users [22, 26, 27, 32]. Rather than requiring deliberate entry, these platforms support persistent, fragmented engagement woven throughout everyday routines [79, 85]. For adolescents in particular, social media use is now closely entangled with studying, time management, and moment-to-moment attention, often unfolding alongside school-work and other responsibilities rather than apart from them.

In the following sections, we describe our examination of teens' phone and social media use and perceptions with close attention

to how teens are thinking about their use in relationship to their routines and strategies for limiting their use.

3 Methods

We sought to understand how high school students perceive their own mobile phone practices, including their expectations for appropriate use and how they believe adults (e.g., parents, teachers, and even broader public media) perceive their practices.

We used a qualitative approach combining two sets of data: a questionnaire to provide descriptive context and capture self-reported behaviors that may be less likely to surface in group settings, and a focus group that enabled richer exploration of shared experiences and meaning-making.

Because teens can be difficult to engage in one-on-one interviews on sensitive or self-reflective topics, we chose focus groups to create a peer-supported setting in which students could reflect on their habits while hearing from others with similar experiences.

We recruited participants from a public high school in a Northeastern U.S. state through personal connections with high school teachers. Two high school teachers, known through personal connections, assisted with distributing and collecting parental consent forms, administering the questionnaire (see Section 3.1), and facilitating access to students during their lunch period. In total, we conducted six focus groups, each consisting of 5–6 students, for a total of 34 participants.

3.1 Questionnaire of Mobile Phone Practices

To gain insights into the high school students' mobile phone practices we distributed a brief, anonymous digital (Google Forms) questionnaire about a week prior to the focus groups. The questionnaire was distributed in three classes from which a subset of students was later recruited for the focus groups. One teacher distributed the questionnaire to two classes.

While there is overlap between the students who completed the questionnaire and those who participated in the focus groups, we were not able to link responses across methods due to anonymity.

The classes we recruited from had a total of 70 students. Students completed the questionnaire during class time. We chose this approach to collect anonymous self-reports that might capture perspectives or behaviors some students would be less comfortable sharing in a group setting, as well as to obtain descriptive information about phone use and perspectives that are not feasible to elicit during a focus group.

We received 47 completed questionnaires¹. Survey participants had an average age of 17; 61% were seniors (12th grade), 28% juniors (11th grade) and 11% sophomores (10th grade).

The questionnaire asked students to report their daily phone use and respond to forced-choice items assessing perceptions of the impact of phones on sleep disruption, difficulty disengaging from their phones, and perceived impacts on studying and academic performance. The questionnaire included 26 items and took an average of 15 minutes to complete.

¹While this number might seem low, we do not know how many of the 70 students were in class the day of the survey, and since students are not sitting with their computers turned towards the teacher, and they were not obligated to fill in the survey, some of them likely spent their time on something entirely different.

Table 1: Focus group participants by gender and grade. See Appendix for full table.

	10th	11th	12th
Male	2	4	8
Female	3	6	10
Total	5	10	19

Given the modest sample size, we report descriptive statistics only. Survey results are not intended to be representative of high school students more broadly but are used to contextualize and complement the qualitative findings from the focus groups.

3.2 Focus Group Procedure

The focus group questions were designed to explore teens' experiences with and perceptions of mobile phone use. Following brief rapport-building and warm-up questions about participants' phone use, the discussion focused on participants' phone use practices, perceived expectations from adults, and strategies for managing or justifying their use.

The focus group sessions were highly interactive, with all students contributing to the discussion. Groups were formed by the teachers, and students appeared comfortable speaking with one another, suggesting established peer familiarity. Each session lasted approximately 30 minutes and was facilitated by teams of two undergraduate researchers. The facilitators coordinated their questions in advance, and all sessions were overseen by the senior researcher on the project.

3.2.1 Focus Group Participants. Participants were recruited from upper-level classes; as a result, many were seniors ($n = 19$, 12th grade, ages 17–18), while fewer were juniors ($n = 10$, 11th grade, ages 16–17) and sophomores ($n = 5$, 10th grade, ages 15–16). Because some of the classes were an upper-level electives, participants were generally mid- to high-achieving students. Table 2 summarizes focus group participants by grade and gender. Full details of participants including pseudonyms are listed in the Appendix.

3.2.2 Focus Group Analysis. We used inductive thematic analysis (RTA) [18, 19] to identify patterns and develop themes that describe teens' use and perceptions of their phones. Our analysis was informed by a phenomenological orientation, prioritizing participants' lived experiences and meaning-making while also supporting the development of conceptual insights that can inform guidance and theory. Initial codes were generated through close reading of transcripts, and were iteratively clustered into preliminary themes capturing patterns in teens' experiences. Themes were then reviewed against the full dataset and refined through multiple rounds of discussion until a coherent and grounded thematic account was reached. Consistent with McDonald et al. [68] and with thematic analysis [19], we did not calculate inter-rater reliability (IRR), use a fixed codebook, or quantify code frequencies, as these procedures reflect a positivist orientation inconsistent with our interpretive goals.

3.3 Ethical Considerations

The study received approval from the university's Institutional Review Board (IRB). Parental permission was obtained for participants under the age of 18. All students under 18 provided informed assent. Participants were informed that participation was voluntary—not associated with course requirements—and that their contributions would be anonymized. Although students were asked to provide their first names during audio recording to facilitate discussion, all names were replaced with pseudonyms during transcription.

3.4 Limitations

This study is not intended to produce generalizable findings, but to offer insight into teens' lived experiences and meaning-making around mobile phone use. Participants were drawn from a single high school and were primarily mid- to high-achieving students, which shapes the particular contexts represented in this study. Additionally, focus groups may foreground shared norms and collective sense-making. These characteristics are consistent with our qualitative approach, which prioritizes depth of insight over breadth of coverage. We also acknowledge the limitation of having only one teaching period available for each focus group, resulting in perhaps not providing extensive time for discussion.

4 Questionnaire Findings

The questionnaires were distributed to gain an overall understanding of how the high school students were using their phones and how much they felt it affected their studies and sleep. We wanted to use these insights as backdrop of the focus groups, since an anonymous survey might reveal slightly different habits than focus groups. It is not uncommon for focus group dynamics to lead participants to a common set of values expressed by for example a dominant voice within the group [88]. With the questionnaire data, more extreme practices were likely to emerge, either contradicting or supporting the focus groups results.

4.1 Daily and Nightly Phone Use

Participants reported using their mobile phones for an average of 6 hours a day. We used forced-choice questions to assess teens use of their phones around bedtime: Over half of the participants (57%) reported having their phone in their hand immediately before falling asleep while almost half (42%) say they put their phone down 30 minutes to an hour before bedtime. The majority of teens (77%) reported that social media scrolling affected their sleep with 66% agreeing that they “sometimes stay up later than planned,” and one in ten (11%) reported that they “frequently lose sleep” due to social media use.

4.2 Studying and Academic Performance

In the context of studying and homework, we asked how often participants checked their phones and how frequently notifications disrupted them during study sessions. Over half of teen participants reported checking their phone every 15–30 minutes, and the vast majority received notifications “sometimes” or “often” while studying.

When a notification occurred during a study session, 17% reported checking it immediately, while 33% said they waited a few

minutes before checking, and 43% reported finishing their current task before checking the notification. Only two of the 47 students reported waiting until their study session was complete before checking their phone; two students did not respond to this question. While we did not ask the teens to define a “study session” in terms of time, it indicated how many students have a hard time controlling attention span with their phone nearby.

We also asked teen participants about their perceived academic performance and whether they felt their social media practices affected it. As noted in the Methods section, the majority of our participants were high achieving students: 55% reported receiving A grades, while 34% reported receiving mostly B’s, the remaining students preferred not to disclose their grades. When asked if they believed their academic performance had been influenced by their social media use, 55% reported no perceived impact, 32% felt their academics suffered and had declined, and 11% reported their social media habits had improved their academic performance.

4.3 Social Media

Teen participants reported substantial time spent on social media, similar to previous research: 28% reported spending more than one hour per session, while 26% and another 28% estimated their session length to be 30–60 minutes and 15–30 minutes, respectively. Only 9% said they spent 5–15 minute during each social media session. The majority of teens (64%) reported that they often or very often found themselves scrolling for longer than intended; an additional 28% reported this occurring sometimes.

When asked about social media’s effect on stress, 17% reported that social media use increased their stress level, while 9% reported that it reduced their stress level. In relation to sleep, 32% of the teens said that social media interfered with their sleep “often” or “very often”, which aligns to our findings that 77% reported sometimes or frequently staying up later than planned or losing sleep due to social media use.

As a management strategy, about two-thirds (68%) reported having tried limiting their social media use. Of these participants, 69% said they saw a slight improvement, while the remainder reported no improvement. No participants reported a significant improvement.

Our findings suggest that teen participants seem to be balancing the desire for social connection and the demands of communication with academics. However, the majority struggled to limit their use and reported staying up late or getting less sleep than they believed they needed due to staying up with their device.

We now turn to our focus groups that offered deeper insights into these self-reported patterns and perceptions.

5 Focus Group Findings

The focus group discussions provided a deeper understanding into how the teens use mobile phones in their everyday lives, including how phone use is embedded in routines, social relationships, and expectations of availability. Discussions frequently turned to social media as a particularly salient site where broader tensions around time, attention, and well-being were felt. Teens reflected not only on how social media shaped their own experiences—such as stress, sleep, and focus—but also on how media and adult narratives about phone use influenced how their practices were interpreted and

judged. They depicted a reality in which phones are provided with expectations of constant reachability, access to information, and social participation, while simultaneously difficult to disengage from. This produced a persistent tension between expectations of availability and efforts to limit use. Indeed, teens describe a catch-22 where they are expected to remain constantly available while also managing the consequences of overuse.

Across groups, participants described mobile phones primarily in terms of communication and social media, reflecting two intertwined infrastructures of obligation: expectations of constant reachability and the pull of socially mediated attention and entertainment. We present our findings according to our three major themes, the ubiquitous presence of phones, the difficulty teens experience in navigating attention to and away from the phone, and finally, the phones themselves as a site of conflict.

5.1 Ubiquitous Presence of Mobile Phones in Teen Lives

Mobile phones were an integral part of participants’ everyday lives, throughout the day. At the study site, there were no formal school-wide policies governing phone use beyond general prohibition during class time, with enforcement left to the teacher. Students were otherwise free to use their phones—during lunch and while moving between classes². While phones had clear utility and necessity—for coordination and communication with peers and adults—conversations frequently shifted towards their negative role in their lives. Participants expressed acute awareness of the need to manage their phone use so that it did not become overwhelming or all-consuming.

Across groups, teens described mobile phones as infrastructural rather than optional, shaping their routines, availability, and social participation. Participants consistently described phones as essential tools for communication and access to information. Andy for example explained how phone use was embedded in daily routines in a way that was inescapable:

“It’s already built into our, like our schedule and like our daily habits and our daily routine. That’s kind of hard for us to move away from, at this point. I feel like from my perspective, it’s like, I can go a day without it. I can go a month without it. But it’d be very hard for me to see myself doing that.” (Andy)

When discussing actual hours spent on their phone, the teens expressed a tension between the amount of hours they felt they should limit their use to, versus their actual time spent on their phones (the survey showed the population of teens being an average of six hours per day on their phones). Andrew and Mike captured this tension during the discussion:

“[...Y]ou need time to be able to, like, check on messages that you have and certain things on your phone that you actually kind of need to use. Social media is the big killer of time if you like. My average is, like

²Note that in the state in which this research took place, legislation proposing a statewide ban on mobile phone use in all public schools—including high schools—was introduced roughly six months after this research took place. Several neighboring states implemented similar statewide bans, immediately following this research.

7 or 8 hours, and it is primarily social media before I go to bed and so..." (Andrew)

"I agree [that the limit should be two to three hours] because I think, like, you need some time to be able to communicate with your friends and your peers, but I think you also need a little bit of time to just, like, decompress. And this is our generation's way to decompress." (Mike)

Several of the focus groups included discussion on how important their phones were for coordinating transportation and rides, especially for the participants who did not have their drivers license yet. Christine for example said:

"[I need my phone to] communicate with my parents. Like, if I know they're on the way home or I need a ride somewhere. So it's like I [need to] be able to tell my friends, like, hey, can you pick me up? Like, contact my parents." (Christine)

Overall, the phones were seen as multipurpose tools that were integrated into their lives from when they woke up, until they went to bed, with many of the teens describing how they would go to bed with their phone in hand, watching something (videos, social media) as the last thing they did that day.

5.2 Navigating Attention

The teens found it challenging to manage their presence in relation to phones, but they described ways, both temporary and situational in which they navigated their attention. Across participants, teens described a gradient of strategies for managing mobile phone use, ranging from silencing interruptions to temporarily removing sources of temptation altogether.

For example, Mike explained that he used "do not disturb" to minimize distractions while doing his homework:

"I do "not disturb" a lot. I feel like that's super helpful because a lot of the times when I'm like, actually doing my homework, the only thing that gets me off track is if I hear something or I am not locked in, [...] I turn off my phone and there's no buzzing." (Mike)

Others describe more restrictive strategies, in addition to silencing their phone, like temporarily deleting apps. Cora explained:

"I feel like, normally around exam season, I try to like, delete all my social media. And I put my phone on silent and I like, sit down in a quiet room and like, walk in and stuff." (Cora)

Teens also discussed their sleep habits in relation to navigating phone use, and often agreed that they stayed on the phone longer than they wanted, which led to less sleep. Several participants explicitly described remaining on their phones until they fell asleep. Some, such as Christine, reported even falling asleep with their phone in hand:

"Yeah. I definitely don't have a good sleep schedule. And I also like, FaceTime my friends a lot. So like sometimes I literally [...] wake up and I'll still be on the phone because I just fell asleep. So there's like some nights where I don't even put my phone down before I fall asleep. [...] I feel like it's a habit for a lot

of people, including myself, [to] just be on TikTok or like another app ... until you fall asleep." (Christine)

Other teens, recognizing the disruptive effect of their phones on sleep, reported putting their phone down thirty minutes to two hours before their bedtime. A few went so far as to put their phone in another room while sleeping. Albert explained how he had changed his habits:

"I put my phone down like an hour before I go to bed. [...] I used to stay on it until I fell asleep. [Now] I just put my phone in the hallway instead of next to my bed." (Albert)

So while the teens were clearly craving social connection, which the phones provided them with (at least as remote communication), potentially at all times, they were sometimes realistic enough about their fallibility as being able to control it.

5.2.1 Social Media: Wanted, Resented, and Structurally Inescapable.

Social media emerged as the primary site where issues around mental health, social insecurity, and attention were felt most acutely and yet also as the thing teens said they could most imagine doing without. This apparent contradiction reflects something important: teens were not unaware of social media's costs, but felt unable to disengage from it unilaterally.

Social media was often described as something teens turned to out of boredom. As Derek explained:

"So you got nothing to do. And then that's what you resort to [scrolling social media]. You can be doing something else with at that time." (Derek)

Others characterized social media as simply difficult to control. When asked about the negative side of social media some of the teens put it in terms of "addiction":

"The problem is like, [social media] is addicting, I just spend a lot of time on it..." (Lokesh)

"I think the worst part about social media is you can get stuck in like an endless loop of like scrolling and scrolling." (Ben)

The teens were fairly open about the mental health concerns related to social media. Even when they did not describe detailed personal experiences, they often referenced effects they had observed in themselves or others. Shahram went as far as to suggest that social media "alters your subconscious mind."

But while they did not describe social media as necessarily introducing new pressures, they described them as amplifying existing ones. Assumptions about social relationships formed quickly and without context. Follower counts read as social standing, an unliked post was interpreted as personal rejection producing heightened self-scrutiny and stress. The platforms' logic actively encourages misreading: what looks like social judgment is often just the algorithm. Yet the emotional weight remains.

Ivy: "I think people use it as a source of validation as to what people feel about them. They'll be like, oh, if so-and-so doesn't like my post, that means they must not like me in real life. But like reality, it might just not have come across their page or whatever."

Mindy: "It's just assuming things about people. It gets really easy and they don't, like [Ivy] said [...] It's

just very easy to assume things about people and then just believe that about her without actually knowing what's true."

Catherine: "And if you have less followers, than your friend or someone you like, go to school with and you're like, oh, why do none of these people... Like, how did she get, like, all these followers and like, I don't have these followers, where do they [...] where are these people? Why do I not know them?"

Social media was also of social value, which the teens highlighted on several occasions. Shahram for example echoed several other people who noted that social media was not only bad, but sometimes motivating and inspirational:

"[L]ike if I see someone on social media that's like a, like a good status, that kind of like motivates me to do better myself." (Shahram)

Others were broader in their expressions of positive value of social media, emphasizing the social connections obtained, as well as information spread. Mahmood expressed how social media also helped him understand the world better:

"I think it's important that while like, social media can have these detrimental impacts, if it's used as a comparison tool, it can also be like, positive; it can connect you to new people and like, develop you a better understanding of the world and like, global conflicts." (Mahmood)

In discussions of what types of apps the teens could live without on their phones, they often mentioned social media as a category. It was evident that while somehow useful and fun, social media was not a priority on their phones as a whole. Kirsten for example replied to the question of how they would be better off without social media:

Interviewer: You would be better off without [social media]?

Kirsten: [Yeah,] I feel like you'd be bored at first and then end up getting more productive because [...] there's nothing to distract you from, like, doing the things that you're supposed to be doing, like, homework. [...] It would force kids to have some sort of hobby that's useful or do something [...] like go with your friends. You don't want to be, like, stuck to your screen all day?

In terms of suggested changes to social media, a common idea was to get rid of comments and likes. Although they sometimes acknowledged the positive feelings they elicited (see above), in the first group for example, they came to an agreement that comments and likes should be hidden. Christine said: "I would delete being able to see who liked or saw my post", and Mike said even more bluntly:

"I think likes are always bad because there's always going to be someone that has more likes than you. Like, unless you're like, the biggest person on the platform, there's always going to be somebody with more likes than you. So I think that just kind of brings

your confidence down, no matter how viral your post goes." (Mike)

This tension has direct implications for how age-based restrictions on social media such as those recently enacted in Australia are likely to be received by teens themselves [34]. Our findings suggest that teens may be more receptive to such interventions than public discourse assumes, particularly when framed around platform design rather than individual failing. What teens consistently pushed back against was not the idea of limits, but the idea that the problem was theirs alone to solve.

5.3 Phones as a Site of Conflict

Not only did the teen participants highlight the duality of practical usefulness versus trying to limit their time on their phones, they also often felt an immense pushback from parents and adult figures in their lives. In particular, the teens were unhappy with what they saw as a double standard from immediate adults. Bridget explained how she felt her mother was much worse than her in getting distracted by her phone:

"I feel like everybody thinks we're, like, so involved. But when I'm talking to my mom and she's on her phone, it's in one ear, out the other, like she does not pay attention to what I'm saying. And then like, five minutes later she'll be like, what? Mhm. Like oh my gaaawd, [...] it's, it's so hard to communicate with her when she's on her phone. Kind of like yeah, [mutual agreement among the other girls in the group] they're saying we're so addicted and we can't get off our screens. But then when she's on her phone like you just can't talk to her." (Bridget)

Misha also expressed very simply how she continuously felt that adults around them were overly harsh on them:

"I think a lot of older generations only view the negative points of it, like only the, uhm, the addiction. They don't think about the benefits [general agreement in the group]" (Misha)

Participants sometimes pushed back against narratives that framed teens as being "addicted" to their phones, emphasizing that phone use was often tied to their availability, particularly for parents and other adults in their lives. Catherine explained:

"[while] it does look like we are on our phones twenty-four seven, [...] the majority of the time there's like a reason or something we're doing, not like just to fancy scroll." (Catherine)

Yet, while they did push back on the negative narratives, they were also able to view themselves from an outside perspective and acknowledge how they seemed "addicted". They used critical language such as "addiction" (Kirsten, Steve) and "stress" (Albert) to describe their experiences. Amy articulated this by explaining the impact that phones have had on social interactions, describing phones as objects that have become nearly an extension of their social presence, inseparable from socializing:

"Kids don't communicate with each other, like, in person. They're just on their phones the whole time. Especially in school." (Amy)

When discussing how long they could be without their phones, many of them framed their response not in terms of personal desire, but in relation to their parents', or other adults', or societal expectations for them to remain within constant reach at all times. Bridget emphasized that this perspective of teens glued to their phones is often misunderstood, illustrating a generational gap how phone use is interpreted, particularly when parents view the teens' upbringing in terms of their own:

"I think it's just important for people that are not us to understand the way we see things, because for like our parents and stuff, they can't get over the past of how they grew up. And so in their heads, like, we have to grow up the same way or we're not doing life right, which is you can't, you can't go back in time and live that way. So I feel like they need to slowly change and kind of understand our side of things." (Bridget)

6 Discussion

Teens' own accounts suggest that the responsibility for managing mobile phone use is often placed on individuals, even as that use is shaped and perpetuated by expectations of constant availability, coordination, and participation. In this sense, what is often framed as overuse or lack of self-control reflects a misalignment between individual responsibility and infrastructural conditions. Teens are asked to regulate their engagement with systems that are socially required and structurally difficult to disengage from. New reports have recently confirmed the high expectation that for example some schools have to children's digital and social media engagement, for in-school content [91].

Across focus groups, teens repeatedly returned to questions of what it means to be "doing life right" according to adults in a world where phones are embedded in their daily routines, social expectations, and parental and institutional demands. While participants readily acknowledged the challenges associated with phone use—particularly around distraction, sleep, and stress—they also described thoughtful, situational strategies for managing these tensions. Teens continually presented themselves as competent actors who were navigating the competing demands of social and societal expectations while also imposing limits for their well being. Their accounts aligns with emerging perspectives that frame teens' phone use not just as simply individual addiction—though that is part of the picture [6, 76, 77]—but as something more nuanced, as a patterned response to social, parental, and institutional demands that require constant availability and coordination.

In this section, we synthesize these findings and discuss their implications for how researchers, designers, and policymakers understand teens' relationships with mobile phones and social media.

6.1 Phones as Infrastructure, Not Optional

A central finding of this study was that teens experience mobile phones as infrastructure—permanent, non-negotiable rather than optional. Phones were reportedly woven into the fabric of their daily lives—schedules, routines, expectations, social interactions—in ways that made disengagement difficult, even when desired. Teens emphasized that the reliance on phones for social presence,

coordinating with peers, and remaining reachable to parents and other adults plays a critical role in their use.

These expectations of reachability and social presence of use place teens in a position where phones are not simply a matter of preference. As prior work on reachability has noted, mobile communication technologies create implicit obligations to be available and responsive [84]. Our findings suggest that these obligations are particularly salient for teens, who are expected to be both autonomous and constantly reachable.

Within this context, teens' references to social media as "addictive" were often describing difficulty disengaging from systems that are expected and socially required. When teens pushed back against narratives of "addiction" it was typically in reference to purposeful and externally demanded uses of their phones rather than recreational use alone.

Teens' accounts suggest that calls for individual self-regulation (or even external restrictions) overlook the structural conditions under which phone use occurs. When phones function as essential infrastructure for social and familial coordination [61], disengagement becomes not simply a matter of willpower, but a negotiation with expectations imposed by others.

6.2 Self-Regulation is Situational and Fragile

Many teens described an ideal daily phone use of two hours, even while acknowledging that their actual use far exceeded this amount. This gap between ideals and practices was not about lack of desire so much as perceived impracticality of doing so within existing routines and expectations. They also still found it difficult to resist excessive scrolling (so-called "doom scrolling") on social media, aligned with how many social media have been designed to lead users into dark patterns [38, 59, 70].

Teens described a range of situational strategies for managing phone use, including silencing notifications, enabling "Do Not Disturb," deleting social media apps during exam periods, or physically placing phones out of reach. These strategies were often temporary and context-specific, activated during moments of heightened academic pressure or specific (nightly) routine. Such accounts resonate with prior work showing that people frequently rely on short-term, improvised tactics to manage digital distraction rather than stable, long-term behavior change [13].

6.3 Social Media as the Primary Site of Tension

Social media emerged as the primary site where issues around mental health, social insecurity, and attention were felt most acutely. Social media was also the thing that teens said they could imagine doing without.

Teens did not describe social media as introducing new pressures, but as amplifying existing ones. Discussion of social validation, follower counts, and even presence reflected the way in which teens are experiencing social media in their social lives, aligning with previous research [5, 74]. For example, assumptions about social relationships could be formed quickly based on follower counts and without context, leading to heightened self-scrutiny, feelings of insecurity, and stress.

This has implications for receptivity to age restrictions on social media, like those currently being imposed in Australia. While such

policies are often framed as protecting young people from social media itself, our findings suggest that the underlying sources of stress, social comparison, validation-seeking, and the pressure to maintain an online identity, are not necessarily unique to social media but are amplified by them. This raises the question of whether age restrictions alone would address the issues teens described, or whether they would simply displace these dynamics onto other digital spaces.

6.4 The Limits of Individual Responsibility

Teens' sense of responsibility for managing their own phone use is often meaningfully at odds with social pressure and expectations. Even while they imagined futures where social media had a diminished role these imagined alternatives were often accompanied by humor or resignation [86], underscoring their perceived impracticality within existing social systems. The environments in which teens operate leave them with little agency over phone use, given the collective nature of communication norms and expectations of availability, particularly from parental figures who expected to know their whereabouts, a practice that has been long term established [3]. As several teens described, moments of attempted disengagement—particularly at night—were especially difficult, reflecting how phones remain embedded in routines (literally in their beds) even when teens are motivated to limit use.

6.5 Design Implications

While we offer design implications, we do not treat these as prescriptive solutions. Instead, we highlight underlying tensions and structural conditions that designers must grapple with, rather than resolving them through simple feature-level interventions [28]. Our findings point to the need for interventions that move beyond individuals or platforms to structural support and shared responsibility for managing digital environments that are distributed across homes, schools, platforms, and policymakers.

For platform designers, it is obvious and has been pointed out before [38, 59, 70, 71], that deceptive or dark patterns in social media need to be addressed. With nearly all our teen participants admitting to spending more time on social media than they actually wanted to, leading to sleep deprivation and/or perceived lower academic performance, changes to the presentation and features of social media could go a long way. Social media and other apps do not *have* to be designed in a usage-maximizing way and could be designed in a way that provides more agency to users. For example, social comparison issues could be reduced by hiding like and follower counts, and notifications could be designed in a less distracting and usage-maximizing way. These features were directly suggested in several of the focus group discussions and agreed upon among our teen participants.

For parents and schools, our findings highlight the importance of aligning expectations around availability and responsiveness. We need to rethink how we frame constant reachability at the risk of undermining teens' efforts to get off their phones. Similarly, educational approaches that frame phones as societal challenges, rather than a moral or individual failing, may support teens as phone bans at schools continue to expand across the US [4] and the rest of the world [82].

School-based phone bans are often justified through mental health concerns, yet they may encounter resistance from parents who emphasize the need to reach their children to ensure their well-being. While more nuanced debates about reachability and everyday coordination may struggle to gain traction in public discourse, safety-based arguments just may. For instance, public discourse around mobile phones in schools is increasingly shaped by safety concerns, including statements by policymakers emphasizing the risks of phone use during emergencies such as active shooter situations, at least in US contexts. However, as one participant pointed out, technology reshapes expectations and ways of thinking. In this context, withdrawal from mobile phones is not a simple reversal, but a design problem in its own right. Families rely on texting to coordinate everyday logistics such as pickups, dinner plans, and after-school activities; teens similarly depend on mobile communication to navigate independence, such as arranging transportation after social outings. If disengagement from phones is increasingly encouraged or mandated, scholars and designers must grapple with how these forms of coordination and care can be supported otherwise. Without such consideration, calls for disengagement risk overlooking the infrastructural roles that mobile technologies have come to play in everyday family life. The problem of phones is collective. This is what teens are telling us.

Future work should examine how teens, parents, and other adults in their lives—including educators—interpret policies and co-construct expectations around dependence, reachability, and responsibility. Such work should explore how collective interventions might meaningfully reduce the burden currently placed on teens to manage complex digital ecosystems on their own. Rather than framing disengagement as an individual act, HCI research could support structured conversations and shared decision-making among teens, parents, and schools. The IDC and HCI communities have highlighted the importance of understanding everyday parent-child communication in technology studies [51].

For example, designers might explore alternative systems that support awareness and coordination—such as limited-function communication tools or context-aware signaling—while reducing the expectation that teens remain continuously connected through personal smartphones. Studies have shown that mobile device use can be a significant source of stress for families, particularly when parents and children negotiate expectations around everyday routines and presence [25]. The teens themselves even suggest some type of de-convergence of the mobile phone, separating different functionality such as music and communication, as a possible option for decreasing screen-time. Leaning into age limitation for certain applications such as social media is a step in this direction, at least for younger teens, but governmental policies are only complementary to agreements within smaller community units and families.

7 Conclusion

We presented results from a questionnaire and focus group study with teens to better understand their everyday mobile phone and social media use, related practices, and how they believe they are perceived by adult figures and media. While teens were forthright about their concerns with excessive use and earnest about their

attempts to limit it, they also pushed back on adults' presumptions and negative reactions toward their mobile phone use. Teens pointed to the hypocrisy of being given this technology—and facing demands to be available, reachable, and social through it—while being told they are “addicted” to it. This suggests that efforts to address the effects of mobile phones may be more complicated than simply banning them or banning specific apps. Rather, we need to collectively frame phones as a societal challenge, engaging platform designers, school leadership, and parents. This research contributes to the increasing body of research into mobile phone use and social media practices in teen life, particularly by addressing the perspectives of teens themselves, in their own context.

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Table 2: Focus group participants

Name (pseudonym)	Gender	Grade
Andy	M	11th
Mike	M	10th
Ben	M	11th
Christine	F	11th
Cora	F	12th
Carmen	F	11th
Anna	F	12th
Steve	M	12th
Suraj	M	12th
Shahram	M	12th
Albert	M	10th
Derek	M	12th
Kirsten	F	11th
Amy	F	11th
Martina	F	10th
Sabrina	F	10th
Harry	M	12th
Catherine	F	12th
Ivy	F	12th
Ashley	F	12th
Bridget	F	12th
Mindy	F	10th
Allan	M	11th
Brandy	F	12th
Misha	F	12th
Brian	M	12th
Emma	F	12th
Calvin	M	12th
Mahmood	M	12th
Kiran	M	11th
Glenda	F	11th
Evelyn	F	12th
Anette	F	11th
Lokesh	M	12th

A Research Methods

A.1 Participant Details

Table 2 provides details of the participants.